



Normally, at this point, I move on to the features section of the review. But, these headphones do not come packed with a LOT of features. There is Spatial sound creation as advertised by Sony, but if you are a professional working in a studio environment, then you would seldom make use of this. When I tried it out, I could feel the difference in the staging of the audio around me.

PERFORMANCE

This is where the Sony MDR-MV1 headphones shined through in all their glory. As we have come to expect from Sony's audio products, the sound signature is well-balanced for the most part and is ahead of its competition when it comes to the overall experience. In fact, their TWS earbuds, the WF-1000XM4, have been the go-to for many here at the Test Centre ever since they were released.

Now, given the use case of these headphones, the tuning of the 40 mm drivers had to be done very carefully to ensure that there is just the right amount of colouration of the audio. And Sony delivered. In the image below, as you can see, the graph is not flat. But when you listen to the headphones and read up on the requirements of the target audience of these headphones, you will understand why Sony tuned these headphones the way that they did.

As it stands for open-back headphones, these headphones have a substantial amount of bass in their audio, which is pleasantly surprising. In the mids, these headphones come close to being neutral, with the highs being boosted again to make up for the bass response, which

would otherwise eat into the metal instruments and vocals of the tracks that these are being used to master. It is done to help the person using these headphones catch all and any irregularities in the highs. And it actually does.

While this would ideally make these headphones the best of the lot, the boost in the highs does more harm than good in this case. If you have read some of our previous reviews, you would know about sibilance. This is a condition where the 'S' and 'T' notes in the sound of a pair of headphones are overly boosted, causing fatigue over long listening periods and, in some cases, headaches as well.

Sibilance is also present in the sound of these headphones, which holds them back from achieving what I would term 'sonic perfection'.

Coming back to the sound signature of these headphones, I would like to talk about the bass response a bit, before moving to the last section of the review. If you notice in the graph, there is an upwards trend in the mid to high bass section of the graph. If these were a pair of consumer headphones with a much more diverse target audience, I would have let this slide. But, given that these are geared towards professionals for whom every note needs to be represented to perfection, the bass boost is a bummer.

During playback, an untrained ear would not even notice the difference, but when you are in a mastering session, if you are not using an external EQ, then the bass in your track could end up being all over the place. In my time with the headphones, I found the response to

be muddy and overwhelming in certain tracks, which I actually had to tune out after a while by using a third-party EQ.

With that said, the Sony MDR-MV1, with their tuning and a bit of adjustment done using a third-party equaliser software, make for a great performing pair of headphones. One which I can recommend to anyone looking for a pair of headphones for use in a closed studio space.

VERDICT

If you made it through to this part of the review, then you'd already know that I would definitely give a big thumbs up to the Sony MDR-MV1 headphones. They deliver on what they promise. Their design, sound, and overall usage experience are something that a few brands are able to match. And these headphones, being priced at ₹39,990 are my new benchmark for headphones in this price range. There are certain areas where Sony needs to work on, like the highs in the sound signature of these headphones, which they need to tone down a bit. But, if you are able to work around that using a third-party EQ or are looking for something like this, then definitely go ahead and invest in these headphones.

—Sativik Pandey

SPECIFICATIONS

Weight: ~223 gm | Headphone Type: Open back, dynamic | Driver Unit: 40 mm | Impedance (Ohm): 24 at 1 kHz | Frequency Response: 5 Hz - 80,000 Hz | Sensitivities (dB/mW): 100 | Cord Length: 2.5 m

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